# Ashes

## By David Sedaris

***TO BE SUNG:*** *Stop This Train by John Mayer*

*Don't know how else to say it, don't want to see my parents go*
*One generation's length away from fighting life out on my own*
*Stop this train, I want to get off and go home again*
*I can't take the speed it's moving in*
*I know I can't*
*But honestly, won't someone stop this train.*

*Lyrics by John Mayer*
*(Check out the melody here [https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=5BTzNX5OMN4](https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=5BTzNX5OMN4))*

## INTRODUCTION

*That's what it feels like . . . when your mother is diagnosed with terminal cancer . . . like a runaway train. All you want to do is to go back to the way things used to be. The way things were before you knew your mom was going to die soon.*

*David Sedaris was a young adult when his mother was diagnosed with stage 4 lung cancer. It was the same year that his sister Lisa got married. A beginning and an ending – the conflict of emotions is clear in Ashes by David Sedaris.*

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**NARRATOR:** **(Pgs 234-250)** After living with her boyfriend, Bob, for close to ten years, my sister Lisa agreed to marry him. They decided the wedding would take place not at a drive-through chapel in Las Vegas but on a mountaintop in western North Carolina.

**MOM:** That's nice. Now all I need is a pair of navy blue hiking boots to match my new dress and I'll be all set.

**NARRATOR:** We liked Bob because he was both different and unapologetic.

**BOB:** *(flipping back his waist-length braid)* You take a day-old pork chop, stab it with a fork, and soak it in some vinegar and you've got yourself some good eatin'.

**NARRATOR:** Bob eventually cut his hair and returned to college, for a career in corporate real estate. He was a likable guy; it was the marrying part that got to me. "My sister's wedding" was right up there with "my recent colostomy" in terms of three-word phrases I hoped never to use. *(beat)*

Three weeks before the wedding, my mother called to say she had cancer. She'd gone to a doctor complaining about a ringing in her ear, and the resulting tests revealed a substantial tumor in her lung.

**MOM:** They tell me it's the size of a lemon. Not a tiny fist or an egg, but a lemon. I think they describe it in terms of fruit so as not to scare you, but come on, who wants a lemon in their lung? They're hoping to catch it before it becomes a peach or a grapefruit, but who knows? I sure as hell don't. Twenty-odd tests and they still haven't figured out what's wrong with my ear. I'm just hoping that whatever it is, it isn't much larger than a grape. This cancer, though, I realize it's my own fault. I'm just sorry your father's still around to remind me of that fact every fifteen goddamned seconds.

**NARRATOR:** My sister Amy was with me when my mother called. We passed the phone back and forth across my tiny New York kitchen and then spent the rest of the evening lying in bed, trying to convince each other that our mother would get better but never quite believing it. I'd heard of people who had survived cancer, but most of them claimed to get through it with the aid of whole grains and spiritual publications that encouraged them to sit quietly in a lotus position. They envisioned their tumors and tried to reason with them. Our mother was not the type to greet the dawn or cook with oats and barley. She didn't reason, she threatened; and if that didn't work, she chose to ignore the problem. We couldn't picture her joining a support group or trotting through the mall in a warm-up suit. Sixty-two years old and none of us had ever seen her in a pair of slacks. I'm not certain why, but it seemed to me that a person needed a pair of pants in order to defeat cancer. Just as important, they needed a plan. They needed to accept the idea of a new and different future, free of crowded ashtrays and five-gallon jugs of wine and scotch. They needed to believe that such a life might be worth living. I didn't know that I'd be able to embrace such an unrewarding future, but I hoped that she could. My brother, sisters, and I undertook a campaign to bolster her spirits and suggest new and exciting hobbies she might explore once she was cured and back on her feet.

*(To Mom)* It'll be great. You could, I don't know, maybe you could learn to pilot small planes or volunteer to hold crack babies. There are a lot of things an older person can do with her time rather than smoke and drink.

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*(to audience)* The cancer was too far advanced and she was too weak to survive an operation. The doctor decided to send her home while he devised a plan. The very word sounded hopeful to us, a plan. *(excitedly)* "The doctor has a plan!"

**MOM:** Right. He plans to golf on Saturday, sail on Sunday, and ask for my eyes, kidneys, and what's left of my liver on that following Monday. That's his plan.

**NARRATOR:** We viewed it as a bad sign when she canceled her subscription to *People* magazine and took to buying her cigarettes in packs rather than cartons. She went through her jewelry box, calling my sisters to ask if they preferred pearls or gems.

**MOM:** Right now, the rubies are in a brooch shaped like a candy cane, but you can probably get more money if you have them removed and just sell the stones.

**NARRATOR:** In her own way she had already begun to check out, giving up on the plan before it was even announced. *But what about us?* I wanted to say. *Aren't we reason enough to carry on?* I thought of the unrelenting grief we had caused her over the years and answered the question myself.

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If she'd had it her way, we would never have known about the cancer. It was our father's idea to tell us, and she had fought it, agreeing only when he threatened to tell us himself. Our mother worried that once we found out, we would treat her differently, delicately. We might feel obliged to compliment her cooking and laugh at all her jokes, thinking always of the tumor she was trying so hard to forget. And that is exactly what we did. The knowledge of her illness forced everything into the spotlight and demanded that it be memorable. We were no longer calling our mother. Now we were picking up the telephone to call our mother ***with cancer***. We realized that any conversation might be our last, and because of that, we wanted to say something important. What could one say that hadn't already been printed on millions of greeting cards and helium balloons? *(on the phone with Mom)* I love you.

**MOM:** I am going to pretend I didn't hear that.

**NARRATOR:** I heard a match strike in the background, the tinkling of ice cubes in a raised glass. And then she hung up. I had never said such a thing to my mother, and if I had it to do over again, I would probably take it back. It

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was queer to say such a thing to someone unless you were trying to talk them out of money or into bed, our mother had taught that when we were no taller than pony kegs.

We gathered together for the wedding, which took place on a clear, crisp October afternoon. The ceremony was held upon a grassy precipice that afforded magnificent views of the surrounding peaks, their trees resplendent in fiery red and orange. My father wept openly during the ceremony. The rest of us studied his crumpled face and fought hard not to follow his example. What was this emotion? My sister was getting married to a kind and thoughtful man who had seen her through a great many hardships. Standing in a semicircle on top of that mountain, it became clear that while Lisa might take on a different last name, she could never escape the pull of our family. The ceremony inspired a sense of loss directed not at Lisa, but at our mother. We knew, everyone on that mountaintop knew, that she had cancer. That she was going to die. *(beat)*

Over the years our mother had repeatedly voiced her desire to be cremated. We would drive past a small forest

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fire or observe the pillars of smoke rising from a neighbor's chimney, and she would crush her cigarette, saying,

**MOM:** That's what I want, right there. Do whatever you like with the remains; sprinkle them into the ashtrays of a fine hotel, give them to smart-assed children for Christmas, hand them over to the Catholics to rub into their foreheads, just make sure I'm cremated.

**FATHER:** *(groaning)* Oh, Sharon . . . You don't know what you want.

**NARRATOR:** [My father'd] say it as though he himself had been cremated several times in the past but had finally wised up and accepted burial as the only sensible option. [My sisters and I] [spent our time together] trying to imagine a life without our mother. Why couldn't she just stay where she was and not have cancer? That was always our solution, to go back in time. We discussed it the way others spoke of bone marrow transplants and radiation. We discussed it as though it were a viable option. A time machine, that would solve everything. I could almost see its panel of blinking lights, the control board marked with etched renderings of lumbering

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dinosaurs and ending with Lisa's wedding. We could turn it back and view our mother as a young girl, befriend her then, before her father's drinking turned her wary and suspicious. See her working in the greeting-card section of the drugstore and warn her not to drop out of school. Her lack of education would make her vulnerable, causing her to overuse the phrase

**MOM:** Well, what do I know? I'm just an idiot, but…

**NARRATOR:** We could turn it back and see ourselves as babies, our mother stuck out in the country with no driver's license, wondering whom to call should someone swallow another quarter or safety pin. The dial was ours, and she would be at our mercy, just as she had always been, only this time we would pay attention and keep her safe. We hoped that by preparing ourselves for the worst, we might be able to endure the inevitable with some degree of courage or grace.

Anything we forecasted was puny compared to the future that awaited us. You can't brace yourself for famine if you've never known hunger; it is foolish even to try. The most you can do is eat up while you still can, stuffing

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yourself, shoveling it in with both hands and licking clean the plates, recalling every course in vivid detail.

Our mother was back in her room and very much alive, probably watching a detective program on television. Maybe that was her light in the window, her figure stepping out onto the patio to light a cigarette. We told ourselves she probably wanted to be left alone . . . frightened and alone, staring at the tip of her cigarette and envisioning herself, clearly now, in ashes.

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## SOURCE INFORMATION

*Author: David Sedaris*
*Book: Naked, Pgs 234-250*
*ISBN: 978-0316779494*
*Publisher: Little, Brown and Company*
*Date (Month/Year): March 1997*

## AWARD HISTORY

*2002 National Qualifier*
*2010 National Qualifier*
*IL State Qualifier*
*KS State Qualifier*

*NOTE: Sheet Music containing the lyrics to Stop This Train can be purchased at https://www.sheetmusicdirect.com/se/ID_No/58115/Product.aspx*

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